# Lesson 20: Interviews: Better Conversations and Good Questions

*English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 2: Getting to Know You*

*Adapted from Getting to Know You - An Intermediate Integrated-Skills Module for English Learners by Sara Ferguson, Grossmont College (CC BY-NC-SA): 2.1: Watch: Celeste Headlee TED Talk; 2.2: Watch: Brandon Stanton Video Mashup; 2.3: Question Practice: Profile Diana Nyad; 2.4: Question Practice: Profile Stanton.*

## In this lesson

You will watch a TED talk by the radio host Celeste Headlee, "10 Ways to Have a Better Conversation", and two videos about Brandon Stanton, a photographer who interviews strangers. Then you will practise question words with a profile of the swimmer Diana Nyad, and write open-ended questions to interview Brandon Stanton.

## Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain Celeste Headlee's rules for a better conversation in simple words.
- Describe how a good interviewer asks questions and treats people.
- Choose the correct question word: who, what, when, where, why, how, how far, how old, how many.
- Write open-ended questions for an interview.

## Key language

| Word or phrase | Meaning in simple English | Example |
|---|---|---|
| multitask | do two or more things at the same time | Don't multitask. |
| pontificate | give your opinions like a speech, as if you are always right | Don't pontificate. |
| go with the flow | follow the conversation; let your own thoughts go | Go with the flow. |
| equate | say that two things are the same | Don't equate your experiences with others. |
| stay out of the weeds | do not give too many small details | Stay out of the weeds. |
| be brief | say it in a short way | Be brief. |
| open-ended question | begins with a wh- word and allows a long answer | What do you love about your job? |

| Word or phrase | Meaning in simple English | Example |
|---|---|---|
| stranger | a person you do not know | Brandon Stanton interviews and writes stories about strangers. |
| attitude | how you think and feel about someone or something | his attitude toward the people he interviews |
| setback | a problem that stops you for some time | She reached her goal despite these setbacks. |

## Rules and explanations

### Celeste Headlee's 10 rules in simple words

1. **Don't multitask.** Put your phone down. Think only about the conversation.
2. **Don't pontificate.** Don't give a speech about your opinions. Be ready to learn something.
3. **Ask open-ended questions.** Start with who, what, when, where, why or how, and let the person describe.
4. **Go with the flow.** Thoughts come into your mind. Let them go, and keep listening.
5. **If you don't know, say you don't know.**
6. **Don't equate your experiences with others.** Their story is not about you.
7. **Don't repeat yourself.**
8. **Stay out of the weeds.** People don't need all the names, dates and small details.
9. **Listen.**
10. **Be brief.**

### Open-ended and closed questions

- A closed (yes/no) question gets a short answer: Did she reach her goal? (Yes.)
- An open-ended question starts with a wh- word and allows a long answer: What do you love about your job?
- The book says: interviewers should always ask open-ended questions.

### Choosing the question word

| Question word | It asks about... |
|---|---|
| who | a person |
| what | a thing or an action |
| when | a time or a date |
| where | a place |
| why | a reason |
| how | the way or method |

| Question word | It asks about... |
|---|---|
| how far | a distance |
| how old | age |
| how many times | the number of times |
| how many + plural noun | a number of people or things |

### Word order (review of Lesson 19)

- Wh- word + did + subject + base verb: What did she think about while she was swimming?
- With "be": wh- word + was/were + subject: What was her goal?
- Subject question (no "did"): Who paddled beside her in a kayak?

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - In Arabic, a question word can come before normal statement order. In English, put the auxiliary before the subject: "What did she think about?" (not "What she thought about?").

## Practice

**1. TED talk.** Celeste Headlee is an experienced radio host who interviews people for a living. Watch "10 Ways to Have a Better Conversation" (https://www.ted.com/talks/celeste_headlee_10_ways_to_have_a_better_conversation) and answer. a) What skill does Celeste Headlee think we need to learn? b) What problems make conversation difficult these days? c) As you hear them, check the rules for better conversation: Don't multitask / Don't pontificate / Ask open-ended questions / Go with the flow / If you don't know, say you don't know / Don't equate your experiences with others / Don't repeat yourself / Stay out of the weeds / Listen / Be brief. Take notes so you can explain each rule to your tutor. d) According to Celeste Headlee, which rule is the most important? e) In your opinion, which rule is the most important? Do you disagree with any rule? Can you add a rule? f) What does she mean when she says "Be prepared to be amazed"? g) Which features did the talk have? Quotes / Jokes / Visuals / Examples / A list h) When you have a conversation, what is your best habit to make it a good conversation?

**2. Brandon Stanton in action.** Brandon Stanton is a photographer in New York. He interviews and writes stories about the strangers he photographs, for his website, Facebook page and book "Humans of New York". Watch the video mashup (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8EPUveE04_c). a) What kind of questions does Brandon ask when he interviews a stranger? b) What do you notice about his attitude toward the people he interviews?

**3. Diana Nyad: question words (book).** First answer the pre-reading questions aloud: Have you ever swum in the ocean? What are some dangers of swimming in the ocean? What is the farthest a human can swim? Then read the profile "Diana Nyad". Fill in each blank with a question word. Use: who, what, when, why, where, how far, how old, how many times. (You will also need "how" and "how many".)

1. Diana Nyad is the first person to swim from Cuba to Florida without a shark cage. _____ is the first person to swim from Cuba to Florida without a shark cage?
2. She swam 110 miles. _____ did she swim?
3. She was 64 years old. _____ was she?
4. Nyad attempted the swim five times. _____ did she attempt the swim?
5. On September 2, 2013, she reached her goal. _____ did she reach her goal?
6. Each time she tried, she had to stop because of storms, jellyfish stings, asthma, and shoulder pain. _____ did she have to stop?
7. She trained by swimming eight to fourteen hours in the ocean every other week. _____ did she train?
8. In order to help her swim in a straight line, her team dragged streamers behind the boat. _____ did her team drag streamers behind the boat?
9. To keep her mind busy, she thought about books and movies, counted and sang. _____ did she keep her mind busy?
10. She gathered a team of 35 people. _____ people were on her team?

**4. Your questions for Diana Nyad.** Write 3 more open-ended questions you would like to ask her. Then ask your tutor to answer as Diana, using only facts from the profile.

**5. Brandon Stanton video profile (book).** Watch the video profile (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Bcm6kwWv090) once. Write a few keywords. What surprised or interested you? Tell your tutor. Then watch it a second time. Imagine you are a journalist writing a profile of Brandon Stanton. What should you ask him to learn more about his passions? Stop the video every one or two minutes and write an open-ended question. Write at least 5. Example (book): What do you love about your job?

## Speak with your tutor

- "Let's have a 5-minute conversation about my weekend. Then tell me which of Celeste Headlee's 10 rules I followed and which rules I broke."
- "You are Diana Nyad. I am a journalist. I will ask you open-ended questions about your swim, one at a time. Answer only with facts from the profile, and correct my question grammar."
- "You are Brandon Stanton. I will interview you about your work and your passions. After 5 questions, tell me which question was the best and why."
- "Now you are the interviewer, like Brandon Stanton. Ask me open-ended questions about my life, one at a time. After each answer, I will ask you one question back."
- "Give me 6 yes/no questions. I will change each one into an open-ended question that starts with who, what, when, where, why or how."
- "Give me 5 answers from the Diana Nyad profile. I will make the question for each answer."

## Read aloud

1. Don't MUL·ti·task. Don't pon·TIF·i·cate.

2. Have you ever swum in the ocean? (↗)
3. How far did she swim? (↘)
4. How many times did she attempt the swim? (↘)
5. Why did she have to stop? (↘)
6. What do you love about your job? (↘)
7. Be prepared to be amazed. (↘)

## Watch online

- Celeste Headlee, "10 Ways to Have a Better Conversation" (TED): https://www.ted.com/talks/celeste_headlee_10_ways_to_have_a_better_conversation
- Brandon Stanton video mashup: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8EPUveE04_c
- Brandon Stanton video profile: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Bcm6kwWv090

## Answer key

**1.** (a, b, c, d and f come from the talk itself, not from the book; check them while you watch) a) How to have a good conversation: to really talk with and listen to each other. b) For example: people send messages instead of talking face to face, and people are very divided in their opinions, so they do not listen to each other. c) All ten rules are in the talk. d) Listen (rule 9: she says it is "the most important one"). e) (example answer) For me, "Don't multitask" is the most important, because many people look at their phones when they talk. I would add: "Smile and be friendly." f) Every person knows something interesting that you don't know. If you really listen, people will surprise you. g) (example answer) Quotes, jokes, examples and a list (the 10 rules). Decide about visuals while you watch. h) (example answer) I ask questions and I don't look at my phone.

**2.** (example answer) a) Short, open-ended, personal questions about the person's life, feelings, problems and dreams. b) He is friendly, curious, patient and respectful. He listens carefully and does not judge people.

**3.** 1 Who; 2 How far; 3 How old; 4 How many times; 5 When; 6 Why; 7 How (also possible: "Where did she train?", answer: in the ocean); 8 Why; 9 How; 10 How many.

**4.** (example answer) Why did you try again after you failed? How did your team help you at night? What did you feel when you reached Florida?

**5.** (example answer) How did you start "Humans of New York"? Why do you photograph strangers? What do you ask people when you first meet them? What is the most difficult part of your work? Who is the most interesting person you have met?

## My notes